

## **Deciphering the Cosmopolitan Characters of Some Selected Ilorin's Compound Names: An Assessment of the Cultural and Linguistic Continuity, 1807-1900**

<sup>1</sup> Omotosho Ishola

&

<sup>2</sup> Wasiu Olayimika Kewulere

### **Abstract**

This study examines the linguistic and cultural continuities that are replicated in existing compound names. It also focuses on the cultural and linguistic diversity in Ilorin's compound naming system. The study adopts a historical research method relying mainly on both primary and secondary sources. The secondary sources include textbooks, journals, official documents from the Ilorin study centres, while primary sources include oral Interviews with people of cultural and linguistic backgrounds of the compounds selected. The purpose sampling was adopted to select compounds that demonstrate clear linguistic or cultural imprints of these diverse groups, ensuring that each selected name provides meaningful insights into Ilorin's cosmopolitan character. This approach allows the study to compare variations in naming patterns, identify cross-cultural influences and highlight continuities in language use. The study argues that the compound names found across Ilorin between 1807 and 1900 are not merely labels of residential spaces but important cultural and linguistic signposts that reveal the city's long-standing cosmopolitan character. By examining selected compound names, the paper demonstrates that the coexistence and interaction of Yoruba, Fulani, Hausa, and Nupe groups, shaped by the Sokoto Jihad, migration, and settlement patterns, produced a distinctive naming culture that preserved elements of each group's language, identity, and social relations. The analysis contends that these compound names embody enduring evidence of intercultural exchange, hybrid identities, and the continuity of Ilorin's multicultural heritage during the nineteenth century.

**Keywords:** Ilorin, Compound, Cosmopolitanism, Culture, Linguistic

### **Introduction**

The early nineteenth-century Sokoto Jihad, launched by Usman Dan Fodio in 1804, significantly reshaped the political and cultural landscape of the central Nigerian region. As the jihad expanded southwards, its influence reached the Yoruba northern frontier, particularly the town of Ilorin, then a provincial settlement under the Oyo Empire. By 1807, Ilorin had become a strategic centre of political realignment as Afonja, the Aare-ona-Kakanfo, allied with

---

**1 Corresponding author:** Omotosho Ishola, Department of History and Diplomatic Studies, Kwara State University, Malete.

Email: [Isholaomotosho2015@gmail.com](mailto:Isholaomotosho2015@gmail.com)

**2**Wasiu Olayimika Kewulere, PhD., Department of History and Diplomatic Studies, Kwara State University, Malete.

Email: [Wasiu.kewulere@kwasu.edu.ng](mailto:Wasiu.kewulere@kwasu.edu.ng)

---

Fulani Muslim clerics led by Shehu Alimi. This alliance, though initially tactical, contributed to the weakening of Oyo's administrative grip and facilitated Ilorin's eventual incorporation into the Sokoto Caliphate as an emirate. The political transformation not only altered governance but also created new social dynamics that encouraged waves of migration into Ilorin.<sup>3</sup>

In the decades that followed, Ilorin evolved into a sanctuary and melting pot for diverse groups fleeing warfare, seeking religious affiliation, pursuing economic opportunities, or aligning with emerging political structures. Yoruba migrants arrived from surrounding towns such as Oyo, Igbomina, Ekiti, and Ibolu areas, contributing institutions of kinship, craft traditions, and linguistic norms. The Nupe, whose homeland experienced both internal political upheavals and the expanding influence of the Caliphate, also migrated southwards, introducing their artisan, commercial, and administrative skills. Hausa settlers, traders, scholars, and soldiers established quarters that reinforced Ilorin's ties to the wider Hausa-speaking northern networks. Fulani migration, initially associated with clerical leadership and political authority, later broadened to include pastoralists, scholars, and administrators who strengthened Islamic learning and governance in the emirate.<sup>4</sup>

By the mid-nineteenth century, Ilorin had thus become a distinctly cosmopolitan urban centre where Yoruba, Nupe, Hausa, and Fulani cultural traditions interacted continuously. This multiethnic milieu was reflected in compound names (ilé) that encoded histories of migration, occupation, patronage, religious affiliation, and lineage consciousness. Between 1807 and 1900, these compounds evolved into markers of Ilorin's hybrid identity, illustrating how cultural and linguistic elements were preserved, transformed, or merged over time. Understanding these patterns provides a unique lens for assessing the continuity and blending of traditions that shaped Ilorin's urban culture during the nineteenth century.

Ilorin's cosmopolitan character is borne out of the history of the city as a political, economic, cultural and religious diversity. Over the years, the area maintained continuous interactions with other groups while being situated in the midst of northern and southern Nigeria. These interactions encompassed various aspects, including frequent exchanges in terms of economy, politics and culture. The area became culturally heterogeneous after the influx of a multiplicity of other cultural and sub-cultural groups, which was conditioned, among other factors, by economy, resources and the significant roles Islam started to play before and when the Shehu Alimi finally settled in the region. Therefore, Islam became the unified factor and facilitated inter-group relations among the various peoples.

The cosmopolitan formation of Ilorin includes multiple groups with different ethnic configurations that could be identified mostly with their economic activities, language and cultural identity. Some of the groups inhabited geographical quarters/settlements of Ilorin, which contributed to the growth and expansion of the areas, with heterogeneous characters over the years. The major and ancient settlements include *Ajikobi, Alanamu, Agbaji, Idi-ape, Oke-Sunna, Oke-Imale, pakata, Balogun Fulani, Gambari, Alore, Itakudimoh, Ita ogunbo, Oja oba, Olufadi, Gegele, Okelele, oju-Ekun* and many more. These areas are the major communities of

---

3 Ishola, O., & Sulyman, K.. An economic diplomatic potentials of Alawo-Nla leather making industry, Okelele, Ilorin East Local Government Area, Kwara State. *Kaduna Journal of Humanities*, 9(2), 2025, PP.134–136.

4 Jimoh, L. A. K. (1994) *The journey so far*. Atoto Press, p34.

Ilorin, under which are numerous compounds or settlements that are named according to their linguistic and cultural affiliations.

Ilorin's compound naming system is a reflection of the cultural and linguistic backgrounds of the people who founded the settlements, and this gives credence to the multicultural and linguistic diversity of Ilorin through the period of its formation. Therefore, this study examined the cultural and linguistic diversity of Ilorin through the lens of compound names in adherence to the language spoken by the inhabitants and observed that these compounds are the symbols of cultural and linguistic survival and continuity of the people.

### **Conceptual Clarifications on Culture and Language**

Culture is an important way of life that distinguishes societies from one another. It is the way of life of people of a particular region and serves as their symbol of identity. It involves the traditional practices and values of a society, which are upheld in a very unique way by the people of that society. Hence, culture is seen as the total way of life of people and is inherent in their belief system, which is sacrosanct based on the cultural ideology of a given society.<sup>5</sup>

Cultural practices include the annual festivals, sacrifices, celebrations, traditional marriage, religious practices, burial rites, naming, music, linguistics, material and non-material culture that differentiate one cultural society from another. However, practising and showcasing these cultural traits in modern society by means of promoting such cultural celebration and usage of artefacts (material culture) can be the source of prosperity, and such prosperity can be communicated with language.

Culture, as a part of the social belief system of African societies, is very difficult to separate from the linguistic system due to the roles language plays in cultural expression, societal formation and socialisation of people. It is embedded in the social practices and affects the interpretation given to cultural values, beliefs, and superstitions. In our societies, language is a very significant part, and no human exists free from words. Language is a system of communication, a non-material aspect of culture that distinguishes one culture from another. It is a vehicle for cultural transmission, unique and a system of symbols, spoken, written or signed, used by humans for communication, expression of thought, and transmission of culture. It is a fundamental component of social interaction and marks group identity, belonging, ethnicity and heritage.

Language is a fundamental human tool that goes beyond communication; it is deeply intertwined with culture and serves as one of its most essential components. In relation to culture, language can be understood as the medium through which people express their values, beliefs, norms, and collective identity. Culture shapes the way people speak, the meanings they attach to words, and the manner in which communication is carried out within a community. Every society develops a unique linguistic system that reflects its worldview, leaving traces of its history, customs, and experiences embedded in everyday expressions. Through this close connection, language becomes not just a way of speaking but a mirror of cultural life.<sup>6</sup>

---

5 Adesina, Y. The forms and significant of Ancient Africa Civilization, Essential Topics in General Studies for Undergraduate, Alhikma University Press, 2012, pp. 43-48.

6 Adesina, Y. The Forms and Significant of Ancient Africa Civilization, Essential Topics in General Studies for Undergraduate, Page 48.

<sup>7</sup>One crucial way language relates to culture is through its role as a carrier and transmitter of cultural heritage. Cultural knowledge, such as moral lessons, religious beliefs, traditions, and customary practices, is passed down primarily through language. Proverbs, folktales, songs, oral traditions, and names carry deep cultural meanings that help younger generations understand and preserve their heritage. Without language, the wisdom and practices that define a people would struggle to survive. In this sense, language functions as the cultural memory of a society, keeping traditions alive across generations.

Language is also central to cultural identity.<sup>8</sup> The language a person speaks often signals their belonging to a particular ethnic or cultural group. For instance, speaking Yoruba, Hausa, Igbo, Nupe, or Tiv is not just about communication but about being part of a community with shared history and values. Language thus becomes a symbol of identity, pride, and unity. When people lose their language, they often lose an important aspect of their cultural identity, which highlights the strong bond between linguistic expression and cultural belonging.

Furthermore, language shapes how people think and perceive their world. Culture influences what people talk about, how they express respect, how they greet others, and what topics are considered acceptable or taboo. Concepts may exist in one language that do not exist in another, showing that language helps structure cultural perspectives. At the same time, as culture changes, language evolves along with it. New cultural practices lead to new vocabularies, while cultural contact through trade, migration, colonisation, or globalisation introduces new words and ideas into a language. Thus, language and culture continually influence one another in a dynamic relationship.

In summary, language and culture are inseparable. Language reflects culture, preserves it, and transmits it from one generation to the next. Culture, in turn, shapes the structure, meaning, and use of language within a society. To understand a people's culture, one must study their language, and to understand their language, one must consider the cultural environment in which it is used. This mutual dependence and the presence of a conglomeration of different ethnic groups and their languages in Ilorin in the years of its formation make the region a cosmopolitan society with the resultant effect of cultural and linguistic diversity continuity.<sup>9</sup>

### **Ilorin Cosmopolitan Characters**

Ilorin, the capital of Kwara State in Nigeria, is widely recognised for its rich cultural diversity and complex socio-political history. As a frontier emirate founded in the early 19th century, Ilorin evolved into a unique melting pot of Yoruba, Fulani, Hausa, Nupe, and other ethnic groups. This cosmopolitan character is deeply rooted in the city's formation under Afonja, a Yoruba warlord, and his subsequent alliance with Fulani jihadists, which gave rise to a multifaceted identity that distinguishes Ilorin from other Yoruba cities.<sup>10</sup>

---

7 Oloso, Y. O. *Politics of Language and Identity in Ilorin Emirate, Nigeria*, Doctoral Dissertation, University of Ibadan, 2017.

8 Olumoh, O.A., *Political and Ethnic Relations in Ilorin, 1823-1992; A Historical Analysis*, Doctoral Thesis, Department of History and Strategic Studies, University of Lagos, Nigeria. 2007, p 21-23

9 Ishola .O., *A Historical Analysis of Ethnic Minorities and Political Turbulence in Kaduna State; A Case Study of Southern Kaduna, 1987-2000*. An Unpublished B.A. Project, University of Ilorin, Nigeria, 2016, pp 7-9

10 Kwara State Ministry of Affairs, Information and Social Development. (n.d.). Ilorin town: *Kwara State of Nigeria town series [Pamphlet]*. Information Division, 2012.

The cosmopolitanism of Ilorin is evident in its language, religion, social structure, and political organisation. Although predominantly Yoruba-speaking, the city retains strong Islamic influences as a result of the Sufi order that was predominant in *okesuna* and especially with the arrival of Fulani leadership. Islam serves as a unifying cultural force, yet the city accommodates significant religious plurality and inter-ethnic marriages, contributing to a complex but cohesive social fabric.

Economically, Ilorin's diverse population has fostered a thriving market culture, with commercial interactions bridging ethnic and regional divides. Its strategic location between northern and southern Nigeria has also made it a transit and trade hub, further enriching its cosmopolitan profile. Culturally, Ilorin displays a heterogeneous tradition in music, dress, food, and festivals, reflecting the syncretism of its multiple heritage streams. The emirate system coexists with Yoruba traditional chieftainships, creating a layered governance structure that accommodates multiple identities. Ilorin's cosmopolitan characters, therefore, are not only a function of its ethnic heterogeneity but also of its historical adaptability and inclusivity. These traits have made the city a case study in peaceful cohabitation and pluralistic urban development in Nigeria.<sup>11</sup>

One of the most compelling illustrations of Ilorin's cosmopolitan identity is the city's diverse linguistic and cultural continuity as preserved and expressed through compound names. In Ilorin, compound names are more than personal identifiers; they serve as cultural and linguistic identity that embody the city's layered history, inter-ethnic interactions, and evolving identities. Compound names in Ilorin often reflect a fusion of Yoruba, Hausa, Nupe, and Fulani linguistic elements, indicative of the city's dual heritage. For example, it is common to encounter compounds that were named in the language spoken by the early settlers; some were named based on the indigenous occupations of the inhabitants. This naming pattern shows the coexistence of different groups, a defining feature of Ilorin's identity since its transformation into an emirate in the 19th century.

The continuity of indigenous Yoruba naming customs, even among Fulani-descended or Hausa-speaking families, speaks to a long-standing process of cultural assimilation and cosmopolitanism.<sup>12</sup> Yoruba compound names such as *ile ara oyo* (compound of those that came from oyo) or *ile alawo-nla* ("a compound of local leather makers by origin") persist within families that came from Yoruba-speaking towns and lineages that engage in such economic activity for generations, revealing how language and economy have served as a vehicle for cultural memory.<sup>13</sup> Moreover, compound names in Ilorin often reflect economic devotion, linguistic values, or historical allusions, functioning as devices that preserve genealogies and community histories, group identities. The inclusion of Yoruba, Hausa and Nupe within local compound names or titles further demonstrates the linguistic and cultural naming system in a cosmopolitan setting.<sup>14</sup>

More importantly, these compound names are not static but evolve across generations, adapting to shifting political and social contexts while maintaining core elements of cultural and linguistic continuity. The replicates of some Yoruba, Hausa, Fulani and Nupe compound names

---

11 Ishola, O., & Sulyman, K.. An economic diplomatic potentials of Alawo-Nla leather making industry, Okelele, Ilorin East Local Government Area, Kwara State, P 138.

12 Oral Interview with Abubakar, S. (*Grandson to Alfa Nda Salaty of Ilorin*], July 15th, 2025.

13 Oral Interview with Alaro, A. 2025, *Alaro Compound, Okelele, Ilorin*, August 7th, 2025.

14 Oral interview with Arowolo, A. *Alaro compound, Okelele, Ilorin* , August 20th, 2025.

like *ile ara oyo* (compound of those that came from oyo, Yoruba.), *ile sokoto* (compound of those that settled from Sokoto and of Hausa origin), *ile gobiri* (Hausa), *ile shinkafa* (Hausa word for rice), *Maimasa* (Hausa), *ile gbodofu* (Nupe), *ile kutigi* (Nupe), *ile alawo* (those that engage in leather work), *ile alaro* (compound of those that make tye and dye), *ile alagbede* (compound that involve<sup>15</sup> in blacksmithing), *ile ongaari* (those that dress for horses as economic activity), *ile alaso* (compound of those that involve in weaving) and many more in Ilorin family compounds underscores the cultural and linguistic continuity of different groups through compound names.

Ilorin's compound naming conventions function as economic, cultural and linguistic identity, which symbolise linguistic and cultural continuity, deciphering centuries of cultural fusion, economic transformation, and social heterogeneity. They serve as a living testament to the city's ability to sustain linguistic continuity amidst diversity, reinforcing Ilorin's status as a unique sociolinguistic and cultural nexus in Nigeria.<sup>16</sup>

### **Some Ilorin's Compound Names: an overview of Cultural and Linguistic Continuity, 1807-1900**

It is customary in Ilorin, probably because of the heterogeneous nature, to name the compounds in the language of the inhabitants, after their family handwork or historical antecedence. At some point in history, indigenous Yoruba groups showcased their cultural heritage through an indigenous economic system, and this is replicated in Ilorin, with its cosmopolitan inhabitants from different ethnicities, languages and economic practices.

The naming of compounds in the language and cultural background of the early settlers in Ilorin's multiethnic society is a practice that encourages cultural and linguistic preservation and continuity. It showcases the enduring legacy of different cultures and ethnic groups that have contributed to the formation of Ilorin as a cosmopolitan community. The compound names are therefore evidence of the heterogeneous ethnic background of all indigenes of the town. To have a good grasp of the linguistic and cultural continuity of the ethnic groups of Ilorin through the cosmopolitan character of the compound names, it would be necessary to highlight and discuss some compound names within Ilorin, their meaning and their historical antecedent.

### **Yoruba Compound Names and Their Antecedence**

***Alawo-Nla compound:*** The word *Alawo-Nla*, loosely translated as those who work with thick hides/skins, became associated with a lineage or family compound of skilled leather workers whose craft became a family tradition passed through generations in *Okelele* area of Ilorin. Ilorin, especially the okelele area of the region, houses a family compound known as *Ile-Alawo-Nla*, and the appellation was given as a result of its indigenous economic practice, which can be traced to the 19<sup>th</sup> century.<sup>17</sup> Awo is a Yoruba word that means skin, which was obtained from cattle, sheep and goats. Historically, *ile alawo-nla* is located in Okelele quarters of Ilorin. The compound is known for the production of local leather for further production of usable

15 Mr. Danladi y, [Oral interview), *Department of History and International Studies, University of Ilorin*.

16 Feyisayo, S. (2023). Indigenous Technology and its Contribution to the Socio-Economic Development of Contemporary Africa. *IJRRSSH*, 10(4), 33.

17 Oral Interview with Mrs Raliatu (potter) Alaro Compound, Okelele Ilorin, January 1st, 2025.

items like bags, belts, shoes and drums, which serve individuals and commercial purposes.<sup>18</sup> Leather work has been for centuries a household job in the area and continues to be the major source of income and livelihood for the descendants and the successors of the *ile alawo-nla*, *okelele area* and was said, according to oral evidence, that *awo* making is an inheritance from forefathers and has become the family artisan passed from generation to generation.

Therefore, *awo* leather making is the compound's cultural and economic identity that is held in high esteem and serves as economic and material culture, not only for commercial purposes but also for compound appellation, the family and lineage economic uniqueness.<sup>19</sup>

**Ara Oyo Compound:** *Ara* in Yoruba means kinship that belongs to a place by birth or origin. *Ara oyo* is a Yoruba language term meaning a group or kinship that is of Oyo origin. Oyo is a Yoruba town that has had a significant impact on Ilorin's history. It was said that the progenitor of the current *Ara Oyo* compound in Ilorin migrated from Oyo. Hence, the name of the compound replicated the language “*ara*” (Yoruba appellation for kinship) and *oyo*, (a Yoruba town where the first settlers came from).<sup>20</sup>

**Alagbede Compound:** *Agbede* is a Yoruba linguistic term, and it denotes blacksmithing. Blacksmiths in Ilorin date back to the 18th century, when the town began to develop as a frontier town between the Yoruba-speaking and northern Islamic regions. Oral traditions suggest that blacksmiths migrated from Old Oyo, bringing with them their technical skills and religious practices (such as Ogun worship, the Yoruba god of iron). This is why the skill is said to be spiritual and connected with Yoruba traditional religion.<sup>21</sup> The early blacksmiths migrated from Old Oyo and practised the craft; therefore, they occupied places and compounds that are still in existence and replicated after the job.

**Alaro Compounds:** cloth-dyeing and embroidery is one of the notable forms of indigenous industrial production techniques in precolonial Yorubaland which in itself was an occupation exclusively conducted by the women folk within the Ilorin society during the precolonial period, embroidery or cloth-dyeing represented an industry that engaged the services of several groups of women who served in various capacities as factory workers, raw material suppliers, carriers, dye makers/mixers, embroidery designers, and hawkers as well as distributors/marketers of finished products. For each of the specialised aspects within the cloth-dyeing industry, the women in precolonial Ilorin were gainfully engaged, and through such practices, the family compounds that engaged in the profession named their compounds after the profession and are still in Ilorin till date, hence contributing to the cosmopolitan economic character of Ilorin.<sup>22</sup>

**Lele Compound:** *Lele* is a Yoruba linguistic term, meaning *chase*, and it arrived in the cosmopolitan compound names of Ilorin as a result of the man known as *Onirin*. *Onirin* was said to be one of the Afonja lieutenants who migrated from Yoruba land of Oyo. According to oral evidence, the founder of *Okelele*, “*Onirin*”, was a lieutenant of *Afonja*, who migrated

---

18 Oral Interview with Mr. Yusuf, (Leather worker) Alawo-nla Compound, Dada Ilorin, January 20th, 2025.

19 Ishola, O., & Sulyman, K. An economic diplomatic potential of Alawo-Nla leather making industry, Okelele, Ilorin East Local Government Area, Kwara State, P 138.

20 Oral Interview with Mr. Kolawole, Alagbede Compound, Ilorin, January 1st, 2025.

21 Oral Interview with Mallam Abdulwasii Alaro Compound, Adangba ilorin, May 2nd, 2025.

22 Oral interview with Sikiru *Lele (Jonkoto) compound, Okelele, Ilorin*, December 19th, 2025.

alongside him to Ilorin in the early 18<sup>th</sup> century.<sup>23</sup> While remaining in Ilorin, he left his colleagues at Idiade and journeyed eastward, hunting and settling into an area which is to be later known as “*Ile Ilorin*” (Ile Ilorin is to be later known as *Ile Lele (lele compound)* and *Ile Jonkoto* much later). However, at this time, the people of Ilorin were finding means of chasing away one *Ohor*, the founder of *Shao*, who was then trying to expand his territory to Ilorin by building settlements in every kilometre from *Shao*; he was said to have vowed that wherever his building is established, that is where *Shao* shall extend. Many powerful warriors in Ilorin tried all means to prevent the *Ohor* of *Shao* from building more settlements, both spiritual and physical. Whenever *Ohor* built a new shelter, people from Ilorin would go there overnight and set it ablaze. This continues for years without success, *Ohor* who is said to be a spiritual creature with seven horns on his head, refuses to go, yet continues expanding his territory toward Ilorin, until *Onirin* comes.<sup>24</sup>

*Onirin*, who was later to be nicknamed “*Lele*” (the chaser), offered to chase away *Ohor* far away from Ilorin to prevent him from taking over Ilorin lands. Initially, people do not believe in his spiritual prowess, saying he cannot do it overnight what powerful warriors and hunters have been doing for years. When *Onirin* was given a chance to prove his worth, he chased away *Ohor*, and he was never heard of again. Hence, *Onirin* was nicknamed “*Lele, Alemokako*”, the chaser who chases a child to the extreme of the village. And his house, Ile Ilorin, was later known as *Ile Lele (compound)*, and adjacent areas and their surroundings are referred to as Oke-Lele (the upper *Lele*).

**Onikoko Compound:** Onikoko compound got its name from the Yoruba word, which means “*koko*”. *Koko* means a local pot made of clay soil.<sup>25</sup> Therefore, the compound name is derived from the historical antecedent of pottery making, and *onikoko* means those who engage in pottery. Hence, *ile onikoko* (a compound that houses those who make pots). Pottery making was one of the dominant forms of indigenous industrial enterprises, which predominantly engaged the services of the female gender in Ilorin during the precolonial period. The compound mostly produced both domestic and industrial utensils in clay forms, which were usually fashioned into objects such as cooking pots, water cans, trays, storage tanks, weavers/dyers pots, and other items of various grades and sizes.<sup>26</sup> The products were also used for spiritual activities by herbalists, diviners and other traditional medical practitioners, especially in Yorubaland and Ilorin specifically.

The major raw material used for production in Ilorin pottery making compound was clay, which had two varieties, namely ‘*amon*’ and ‘*ayan*’. Ilorin pottery compound provided gainful employment for several groups of women and was a source of revenue for the emirate’s treasury during the 19th century. The demand for products of the Ilorin pottery was high in the precolonial period as the job received patronage from customers who engaged in commercial

23 Olanrewaju, P. *An Appraisal of the contribution of Sheikh Abdulrahman Alabidun to the Islamic Scholarship in Okelele, Ilorin*, B.A’s Project, Department of History and Diplomatic Studies, Kwara State University, Malete, 2025, Pp5-10.

24 Olanrewaju, P. *An Appraisal of the contribution of sheikh abdulrahman alabidun to the islamic scholarship in okelele, Ilorin*, 2025.

25 Olawuyi, H. O., & Rabi, R. A. (2024). *O-ni prefix surname markers among Ilorin-Yoruba people: A socio-onomastics analysis with implications for Yoruba language pedagogy*. Indiana University Press.

26 Ologele, S. A. (2012). Non-Yoruba influences in Ilorin place and compound names. In *Theoretical and historical perspectives of language: Arabic as a case study*.

relations at the different markets within the Yoruba country, and also in parts of the Nupe region, as well as in Hausa land.<sup>27</sup>

### **Nupe Compounds (Akatas) and Their Antecedence**

**Gbodofu Compound (Akatas in the Nupe language):** *Gbodo* is the Nupe settlement in Bida. *Gbodo* is the name of the village where the inhabitants of present-day *gbodofu* Ilorin occupy, while “*Fu*” is the Nupe linguistic term which means area.<sup>28</sup> Therefore, the word *gbodofu* means a compound occupied by people from the *Gbodo* area in Bida. According to oral evidence, the progenitor of the family had been in Ilorin before the establishment of the emirate system in the town. It was also discovered that Mallam Hassan, the founder of *Gbodofu* compound in Ilorin, came from Bida at the invitation of Sheikh Alimi. Sheikh Alim wanted Mallam Hassan to assist him in building Ilorin. The invitation was made possible because they had known each other at Gwandu. Hence, the *gbodofu* compound of Ilorin has the antecedent from Bida, Nupe land and the compound is named in Nupe linguistic style, which happens to be the language of the founder, thereby forming linguistic diversity of Ilorin Emirates.

**Kutigifu Compound:** Danlad opines that the *Kutigifu* of Ilorin is the *Maliki* compound. *Alfa Maliki* was the third Imam of the *Arowasi* mosque in *Kutigifu*. *Alfa Maliki*’s people came from *Gana Gaji* near *Lafiagi*. Also in *Kutigifu* is the *Tetengi* compound. *Tetengi* also traces its roots to Bida, not far from *Kutigifu*, where the *Onileke* compound, whose forefather also came to Ilorin from *Bida*. The first Nupe to settle in *Onileke* compound, *Oke-Sunna* area was *Sheikh Muhammad*, who was based in *Danbafu* compound between the 19<sup>th</sup> century and the early 20<sup>th</sup> century. It is therefore interesting to note that *Kutigifu*, *Tetengi* and *Danbafu* are Nupe linguistic styles that are Nupe compound names in Ilorin, which diversify the area.

**Alfa Nda Salaty (malefu) Compound:** *Nda* is a Nupe language, which means “man”. Therefore, the family is named after a Nupe man who sought a blessing upon the soul of the holy Prophet, in the Nupe language. *Nda Salaty* family Compound of *Malefu* is among the most important Nupe families in *Alanamu* quarters of Ilorin due to the popularity of the scholar and spirituality bearing that name. The founder of *Malefu* was Sheikh Abubakar, who came to Ilorin from Bida. He first came to *Gbodofu* in the Balogun Fulani area before migrating to Balogun Alanamu quarters to found *Malefu*. He was the father of Sheikh *Nda Rufai*, who was later known as Sheikh *Nda Salaty*. Sheikh *Nda Rufai* acquired the name due to his love for the Arabic poem which goes thus: *salati wa Tasli mi.....*, and he was well known for his scholastic and spiritualist up to the time of his death.<sup>29</sup>

**Liman Compound:** Danlad also postulated that, at the core of Gambari is *Ile Liman*, which is now the Imam Gambari compound, as it is alternatively called. The Imam Gambari compound is of Nupe origin. According to a source, the progenitor of Imam Gambari’s family, Abdulmumini Dogo, came to Ilorin from Bokani, a Nupe town, to join Doshe, who was to

27 Raji, A. O. Y., Olumoh, A. O., & Abejide, S. T. (2013). Women and their role in the economy of pre-colonial Ilorin, northern Nigeria. *Arabian Journal of Business and Management Review* (OMAN Chapter), 3(5), 43-54

28 Oral Interview with Ibrahim, H. *Gbodofu Compound, Balogun Fulani, Ilorin*, August 23rd, 2025.

29 Oral interview Abubakar, Salaty. *Grandson to Alfa Nda Salaty of Ilorin*, July 15th, 2025.

become the first Balogun Gambari of Ilorin. Abdulmumini Dogo's family was originally from Kano before being assimilated into the Nupe in Bokani.<sup>30</sup>

However, it should be noted that there are several Nupe compounds that are in the Gambari/Ojagboro axis. For example, there is Ile Tapa in Makaranta, in the Oke Sunna area and Ile Onisana in the same Oke Sunna. There is also Isale Tapa in Ojagboro area, as well as Koro and Ile Balugi in Gambari area. Likewise, we have people of Nupe origin Iso Ori compound in Isale Koko Ndarabi compound in Karuma, Ile Onimewa in Okesunna, Bolanta compound in Ile film area. All of these compounds are Nupe compounds in Ilorin, and it could be understood that their formation are Nupe linguistic dialect. Also, some of the other categories include *danbanfu*, *segbafu*, *sakufu*, *yerefu*, *niankofu* and *shotafu*.

### Hausa/Fulani Compound and Their Antecedence

**Imam Fulani Compound:** The Imam Fulani compound of Ilorin emirates are said to be of Fulani origin. The current settlement was said to be a result of the influx of people migrating into Ilorin in the 18<sup>th</sup> century and was conditioned by religion and trade. However, the name is obtained as a result of the religious role played by the descendants of the compound and the position is held by the people of Fulani origin, hence Imam Fulani Compound.<sup>31</sup>

**Sokoto Compound:** The name Sokoto has both historical and linguistic significance. *Sokoto* is derived from the Arabic word *suk*, which means *market* or place of commerce. Over time, this Arabic word was adapted into Hausa as *sakwato* and later anglicised to *Sokoto* by the British. Therefore, *Sokoto* means a marketplace or commercial centre reflecting its historical role as a hub for trade and Islamic scholarship. However, the descendants of *Sokoto* compound in Ilorin are said to be of Fulani origin migrated from Sokoto state. The name is also replicated in the compound of the migrants, and it forms the cosmopolitan character of Ilorin through compound names.<sup>32</sup>

However, it should also be noted that several other Hausa compounds include the *Nababa* compound in *okekere*, which means "something that belongs to father". We have *Shinkafa* compound around the area, likewise *Mazankorai Maimasa* compounds in Gambari. All these are vocabularies for compounds with Hausa linguistic identities in Ilorin.

### Conclusion

The study examined the cosmopolitan nature of Ilorin through the lens of compound names. The study explores the compound names with their linguistic and cultural traits, showing their significance and the process of forming cosmopolitanism and legacy in the linguistic and cultural continuity of different tribes in Ilorin city. Cultural and linguistic continuity is borne out of the surviving compounds that are named in the language of the ethnic group that was settled in the areas. Also, the surviving economic activities of these groups are a testimony to cultural and linguistic continuity.<sup>33</sup> This means that the compound names in Ilorin are the symbols of cultural preservation and identity formation that distinguish ethnic groups from one

---

30 Yusuf, S. D. (2016). A history of Nupe settlers in Ilorin and their settlement pattern: 19th century to 20th century. *Ilorin Journal of History and International Studies*, 6(1), 55–56.

31 Oral interview with Kadriya, S. *Sokoto Compound, Okekere, Ilorin*, July 12th, 2025.

32 Oral interview with Dasuki, M. *Baruba quarters, Ilorin*, May 14th, 2025.

33 Ologele, S. A. (2012). Non-Yoruba influences in Ilorin place and compound names. In *Theoretical and historical perspectives of language: Arabic as a case study*.

another. It locates the ethnic group to their historical antecedents and commercial activities and sheds light on the role of heterogeneous groups in state formation.<sup>34</sup> However, not all the compound names are captured, which creates a vacuum for further research studies in another context and scope.

---

34 Oloso, Y. O. (2017). Politics of language and identity in Ilorin Emirate, Nigeria [Doctoral dissertation, University of Ibadan].

## **References**

- Alapansanpa, S. O. Y. (2021, March 13). Ilorin's complex history: A plea for accurate representation, unity. *Nigerian Tribune*. <https://tribuneonlineng.com/ilorins-complex-history-a-plea-for-accurate-representation-unity/>
- Al-Ilory, A. A. (1987). *Theoretical and historical perspectives of language: Arabic as a case study*. Islamic Publications Bureau.
- Ambali, M. A. (1987). *Western education in an Islamic town, Ilorin: Prospects and development* [Address]. Ilorin Grammar School.
- Feyisayo, S. (2023). Indigenous technology and its contribution to the socio-economic development of contemporary Africa. *IJRSSH*, 10(4), 33.
- Ishola, O., & Sulyman, K. (2025). An economic diplomatic potentials of Alawo-Nla leather making industry, Okelele, Ilorin East Local Government Area, Kwara State. *Kaduna Journal of Humanities*, 9(2), 134–136.
- Jimoh, L. A. K. (1994). *The journey so far*. Atoto Press.
- Jimoh, L. A. K. (2021, August 22). Ethno-cultural complexity of Ilorin. *IncNews247*. <https://incnews247.com/ethno-cultural-complexity-ilorin-lak/>
- Kolawole, P. K. (2025). An appraisal of the contributions of Sheikh AbdulRahman Alabidun to Islamic scholarship in Okelele, Ilorin, 1920–1954 [Unpublished bachelor's project]. Kwara State University.
- Kwara State Ministry of Affairs, Information and Social Development. (n.d.). *Ilorin town: Kwara State of Nigeria town series* [Pamphlet]. Information Division.
- Lloyd, S. A. B. (1971). *Gwandu Emirates in the nineteenth century with specific reference to political relations: 1817–1903* [Doctoral dissertation, University of Ibadan].
- Olaoye, R. A. (1989). A study of twentieth century weaving in Ilorin. *African Study Monographs*, 83–84.
- Olawuyi, H. O., & Rabi, R. A. (2024). *O-ní prefix surname markers among Ilorin-Yoruba people: A socio-onomastics analysis with implications for Yoruba language pedagogy*. Indiana University Press.
- Ologele, S. A. (2012). Non-Yoruba influences in Ilorin place and compound names. In *Theoretical and historical perspectives of language: Arabic as a case study*.
- Oloso, Y. O. (2017). *Politics of language and identity in Ilorin Emirate, Nigeria* [Doctoral dissertation, University of Ibadan].
- Omoiya, S. Y. (2013). Direct consequence of British political diplomacy on African traditional structure: A study of changes in Ilorin, 1895–1915. *IOSR Journal of Humanities and Social Science (IOSR-JHSS)*, 7(2), 15.
- Otukoko, I. S. (2012). From traditionalism to democratic radicalism: A re-examination of Talaka Parapo phenomenon, 1954–1958. *Journal of African Politics and Society*, 1(2), 244.
- Raji, A. O. Y., Olumoh, A. O., & Abejide, S. T. (2013). Women and their role in the economy of pre-colonial Ilorin, northern Nigeria. *Arabian Journal of Business and Management Review (OMAN Chapter)*, 3(5), 43-54
- Tosho, A. H. (2018). Contribution of Islamic scholarship in Okelele, Ilorin: An appraisal of Alfa Musa Atere, 1770–1907 [Unpublished bachelor's project]. University of Ilorin.
- Yusuf, S. D. (2016). A history of Nupe settlers in Ilorin and their settlement pattern: 19th century to 20th century. *Ilorin Journal of History and International Studies*, 6(1), 55–56.

## **Oral Interviews**

- Abubakar, S. (2025, July 15). Grandson to Alfa Nda Salaty of Ilorin [Oral interview].
- Alaro, A. (2025, August 7). Alaro compound, Okelele, Ilorin [Oral interview].

- Arowolo, A. (2025, August 20). Alaro compound, Okelele, Ilorin [Oral interview].
- Danladi, Mr. (2025, March 15). Department of History and International Studies, University of Ilorin [Oral interview].
- Dasuki, M. (2025, May 14). Baruba quarters, Ilorin [Oral interview].
- Ibrahim, H. (2025, August 23). Gbodofu Compound, Balogun Fulani, Ilorin [Oral interview].
- Kadriya, S. (2025, July 12). Sokoto Compound, Okekere, Ilorin [Oral interview].
- Sikiru, A. (2025, May 14). Lele (Jonkoto) compound, Okelele, Ilorin [Oral interview].